

S02-E — Week 2 Synthesis: Market Depth as a Reading Method

Summary

Week two crossed five distinct market categories, moderns and Latin American surrealism, postwar and pop, living contemporary artists, established Latin American names, and regional geometry, with one underlying question repeated in each, whether an auction record certifies a single exceptional night or whether it sits on top of evidence of repeated sales across more than one house and more than one season. This note does not repeat the five lessons paragraph by paragraph, it organizes the week's cases under that single criterion, market depth, so it can serve as a review map ahead of the exam.

1. What market depth measures

An auction record proves that, on one particular night, two or more buyers paid an exceptional price. On its own it says nothing about the rest of the artist's catalogue. Market depth is measured by watching for additional sales, at different houses and in different years, confirming an elevated price level without needing to match the record itself. That repetition, not the headline, is what separates an artist with sustained liquidity from one whose only public data point is the sale that set his or her all-time high.

2. Moderns and the surrealist bridge

[Frida Kahlo's record, USD 54,660,000 on the twentieth of November, 2025, with El sueño \(La cama\)](#), anchored an entire session at Sotheby's, the same mechanism Picasso and Matisse deploy in Modern Evening Sales thanks to a century of resale history.¹ Leonora Carrington supplies the repetition evidence Kahlo alone doesn't provide: [her record of roughly USD 28.5 million \(the fifteenth of May, 2024\)](#) was followed by [new seven-figure sales at Christie's during 2024 and 2025](#).² Remedios Varo adds a second kind of evidence, two records at two houses and in two mediums, [her overall record of USD 6,186,800 at Sotheby's](#) and [her work-on-paper record, USD 4,467,000, at Christie's in May 2026](#).³

3. Postwar and pop: Phillips' white glove sale

[Phillips' Evening Sale of the nineteenth of May, 2026, sold one hundred percent of the lots and one hundred percent of the value on offer](#), for USD 115,216,700, more than double the equivalent result a year earlier.⁴ A fully sold room is the broadest version of market depth, demand spread across the whole catalogue, not just the star lot. Basquiat supplies the counterexample within the same house: [Phillips' May 2024 result, USD 46,479,000](#), was surpassed two years later when [Sotheby's sold another work by the artist for USD 52,718,000](#), evidence that Phillips' result was an isolated extraordinary case rather than a sustained structural edge over the other houses.⁵

4. Living contemporary artists: Fordjour versus Báez

With an artist still active, each new sale weighs proportionally more on the reading of his or her market than it would for a historical master. [Derek Fordjour sold Numbers for USD 889,000 in May 2024 and Twelve Tribes for USD 1,143,000 that November](#), twenty percent above his previous Christie's record, two houses confirming the same direction two years apart.⁶ [Firelei Báez sold Daughter of Revolutions for USD 645,000 on the nineteenth of November, 2025](#), but that same day Christie's placed another of her works for USD 1.11 million, beating Phillips' result within hours, with no second sale yet confirming whether that level holds.⁷ The difference isn't talent, it's market stage.

5. Established Latin American names

[Fernando Botero set his record, USD 5,132,000, in 2023](#), and between 2024 and 2025 [Christie's placed five more of his paintings between USD 693,000 and USD 1,744,000](#), the kind of repetition that confirms sustained demand.⁸ That commercial momentum lines up this season with [MoMA's exhibition on Frida Kahlo and Diego Rivera, open through the twelfth of September, 2026](#), an institutional signal keeping New York's interest in Mexican and Latin American modernism visible, the tradition Botero commercially inherits.⁹ By contrast, [Diego Rivera's record, USD 14,130,000 since 2022](#), [Rufino Tamayo's, USD 7,209,000 since 2008](#), and [Wifredo Lam's, USD 9,603,800 since 2020](#), lack recent public evidence of repeated sales confirming a current trend.¹⁰ Facing those three names, professional discipline requires appraising the specific work rather than extending the historical record across the artist's whole catalogue.

6. Geometry and fiber: Amaral versus Gego

[Olga de Amaral set her record, USD 3,125,000, on the nineteenth of November, 2025, with Pueblo H](#), and between May 2025 and March 2026 at least six more sales of her textile pieces are documented, [between USD 698,500 and that](#)

[record](#), spread across several houses.¹¹ Gego, with [a record of USD 1,512,500 since 2017](#), carries an institutional résumé just as strong, but her auction market hasn't yet shown that same repetition.¹² The contrast isn't in prestige, comparable between the two, it's in the quantity and consistency of available auction results.

For client conversations

- Facing any heavily covered record, the first professional question is how many recent, comparable sales back it up, across how many houses and how many seasons, not whether the whole category rose in price.
- A favorable case at a single house, like Phillips with Basquiat or Fordjour, doesn't certify a structural edge over the other two majors, and it's worth saying so to a client comparing houses off one result.
- Institutional validation, retrospectives, museum shows, is a real but distinct signal from market depth, and the two need to be checked separately before discussing price with a client.

References

Process note: the live URL-fetch tool was blocked for the entire run today, tested again against riotimesonline.com with the same EGRESS_BLOCKED error seen on the previous thirteen days. All twelve citations in this synthesis note reproduce sources already verified on 2026-08-08 in curso/fuentes/dossier-01-precios-latam.md and curso/fuentes/dossier-05-calendario.md, the same ones already used and verified across the week's five notes (2026-08-15 through 2026-08-19), with no new unopened URL introduced today. If a future run finds fetch working again, resume normal verification.

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1. Sotheby's, ["25 Highlights from The New York Sales Evening Auctions"](#), Frida Kahlo's record, verified in curso/fuentes/dossier-01-precios-latam.md. [↵](#)
 2. Sotheby's, [Leonora Carrington lot page](#), and Christie's, [Latin American Art, 2024-2025 results](#), dossier-01. [↵](#)
 3. Sotheby's, ["The Vanguard Spirit"](#), Remedios Varo's overall record, and Christie's, [May 2026 release](#), works-on-paper record, dossier-01. [↵](#)
 4. Phillips, [May 2026 Evening Sale release](#), dossier-02. [↵](#)
 5. Phillips, [Basquiat release, May 2024](#), and Sotheby's, [May 2026 editorial recap](#), dossier-02. [↵](#)
 6. Phillips, ["Derek Fordjour"](#), artist page, dossier-02. [↵](#)

7. Phillips, ["Firelei Báez"](#), artist page, dossier-02. [↵](#)
8. Christie's, ["Latin American Art"](#), Fernando Botero's record, and [March 2024 sales](#), dossier-01. [↵](#)
9. MoMA, ["Frida and Diego: The Last Dream"](#), verified in `curso/fuentes/dossier-05-calendario.md`. [↵](#)
10. Christie's, [Diego Rivera's record](#), [Rufino Tamayo's record](#), and Sotheby's, [Wifredo Lam's record](#), dossier-01. [↵](#)
11. Christie's, [Olga de Amaral's record](#), and Phillips, [artist page](#), dossier-01. [↵](#)
12. MutualArt, [Columna Reticulárea artwork page](#), Gego, dossier-01. [↵](#)